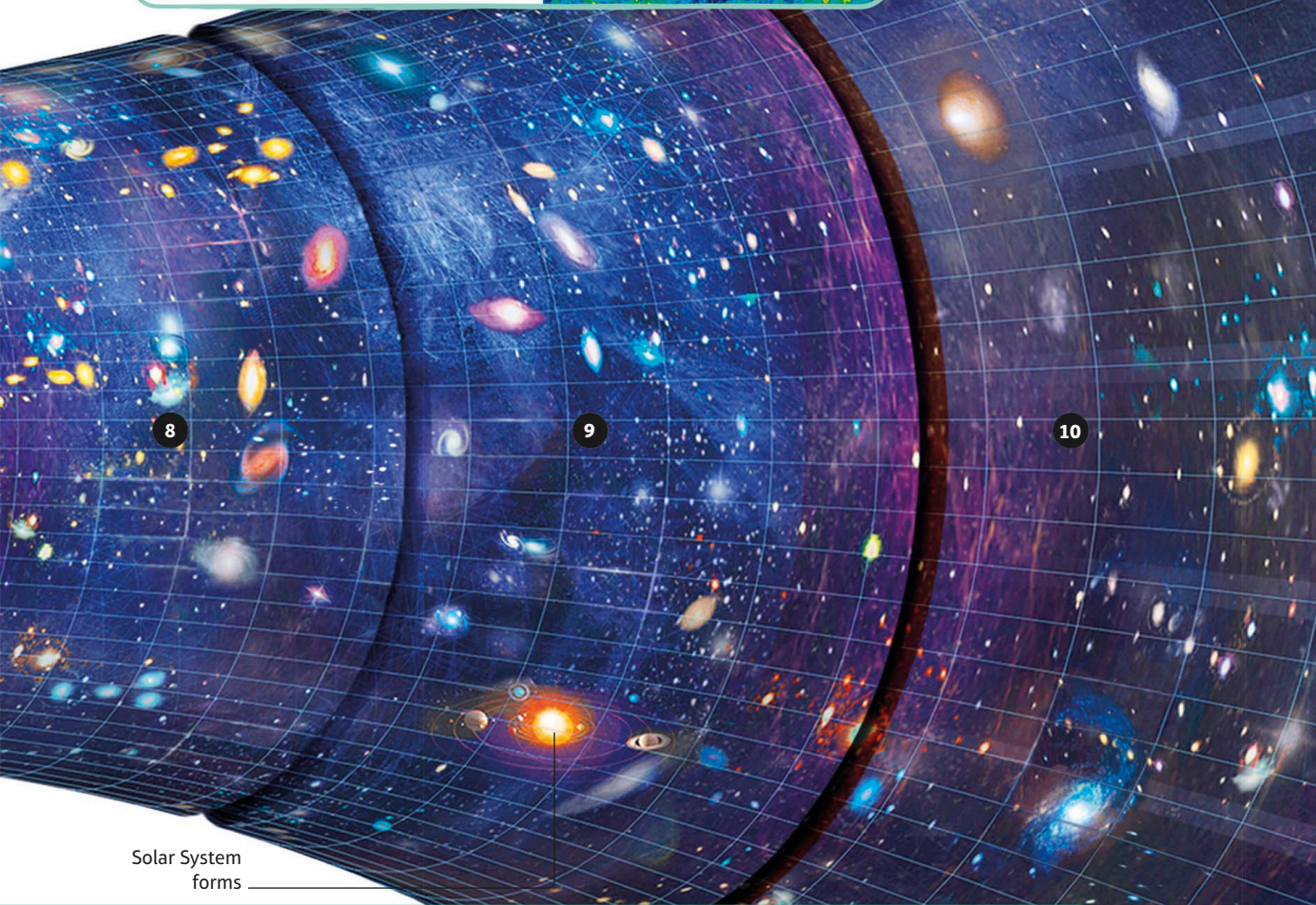
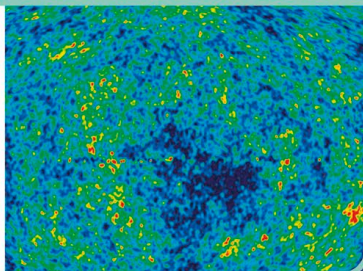


AFTERGLOW OF CREATION

Heat radiation from the Big Bang fills the Universe. Astronomers map it with radio telescopes: the best view has come from the Planck space telescope orbiting Earth. This image shows small differences in temperature in the radiation, with red being the hottest.



Solar System
forms

- 6** Swirling clouds of hydrogen and helium gas are pulled into dense clumps by the gravity of mysterious dark matter.
- 7** After 500 million years, the first stars are born in galaxies centred on quasars (hot gas clouds around massive black holes).
- 8** After 5 billion years, the Universe consists of vast clusters of galaxies arranged in threads with gigantic voids between them.
- 9** Some 8 billion years after the Big Bang, the expansion of the Universe begins to accelerate, driven by dark energy.
- 10** Now 13.8 billion years old, the Universe grows ever larger, but will eventually fade away as stars die.